Findings - Discovery Study on ZocDoc Experience

Introduction

This report presents the findings from a recent Discovery study aimed at understanding why patients are or are not scheduling appointments using our digital services. The study focused on uncovering insights to improve the user experience and increase the adoption of our online scheduling platform. Participants were observed interacting with ZocDoc, a third-party platform that helps users find healthcare providers. The study involved comprehensive feedback from patients to identify friction points and successes in the process.

Methodology

Participants were asked a series of questions during discovery interviews to gather their experiences and opinions on various aspects of using ZocDoc. The questions covered topics such as personal experiences searching for a primary care provider (PCP), challenges faced, thoughts on the guided search experience, and preferences for features like voice input and AI assistance.

Key Findings

First Impressions of ZocDoc

Participants value:

- **Insurance Information**: The inclusion of insurance information boosts confidence in coverage and aids in selecting providers.
- **Variety of Doctor Options**: The availability of various specialists, not just primary care physicians (PCPs), enhances the service's appeal. When irrelevant providers are included (i.e., searching for a Cardiologist and an OB/GYN provider embedded within the search results), trust in the service quickly erodes, potentially leading to abandonment.
- **Search Page Clarity**: The straightforwardness of the search page, focusing on essential elements like insurance, location, and doctor type, is appreciated.

Participants have concerns about:

- **Insurance Compatibility**: Hesitation regarding the service's ability to filter doctors based on specific insurance plans.
- **Initial Search Confusion**: Potential confusion in the interface, with one participant mistakenly believing they were viewing search results without initiating a search.

Sorting Search Results

Participants find sorting functionality unclear and disorganized, with issues in ordering by location and specialty visibility:

- **Sorting Functionality is Unclear (2 mentions)**: Confusion and frustration due to unclear sorting functionality.
- **Disorganized Experience Due to Titles and Practices (1 mention)**: Confusing titles and the mix of practices versus individuals.
- **Inability to Order by Location (1 mention)**: Need to sort search results by distance, but this option is unavailable or unclear.
- **Mismatch in Search Results (1 mention)**: Frustration with search results showing primary care doctors instead of the requested specialists.
- **Need for Prominent Specialty Information (1 mention)**: Desire for doctor specialties to be more prominently displayed.

Map Features of ZocDoc

Participants find the map feature useful for logistics and traffic, but some prefer filtering by location:

- **Map Feature Aids Logistics (2 mentions)**: Helpful for assessing traffic conditions and narrowing down search results.
- **Preference for Location Filtering (1 mention)**: Preference for filtering by location over using the map, finding the order of results confusing.

Ratings and Reviews

Participants value detailed reviews and information for informed decisions, with a preference for recent reviews and availability over high ratings:

- **Preference for Detailed Reviews (3 mentions)**: Preference for reading detailed reviews for a comprehensive understanding, despite openness to AI-generated summaries.
- **Importance of Appointment Availability (2 mentions)**: Prioritization of appointment availability over high ratings when choosing a doctor.
- **Value of Comprehensive Information (2 mentions)**: Appreciation for detailed information like reviews, network status, and board certifications.
- **Significance of Recent Reviews (2 mentions)**: Suggestion to show the age of reviews, as recent negative reviews may indicate a decline in quality.
- **Trust in Google Reviews (2 mentions)**: Value placed on Google reviews, checking both positive and negative feedback to assess a doctor's trustworthiness.

Sponsored Listings in Search Results

Participants express skepticism about sponsored listings, preferring clear labeling and relevant, high-quality results:

- **Skepticism Towards Sponsored Listings (3 mentions)**: Skepticism about the quality of sponsored listings, preferring to rely on reviews and ratings.
- **Preference for Clear Labeling (3 mentions)**: Acceptance of sponsored listings if they are clearly marked, understanding the

need for revenue.

- **Irrelevance of Sponsored Results (2 mentions)**: Frustration with sponsored results often being irrelevant to specific search needs.
- **Desire for Quality Control in Sponsorship (2 mentions)**: Suggestion for a cutoff for sponsored listings based on ratings to ensure quality.

Guided Search

Participants have mixed feelings about the guided search process, with preferences for preliminary questions and simplicity:

- **Preference for Preliminary Questions (5 mentions)**: Appreciation for preliminary questions to narrow down search results, valuing time-saving and specificity.
- **Concerns About Guided Process Timing (4 mentions)**: Feeling that the guided process should be introduced earlier and not as a roadblock when searching for providers.
- **Desire for Interface Options (3 mentions)**: Suggestion for multiple interface options, such as guided tours or AI assistance, to cater to different preferences.
- **Skepticism About Customization (3 mentions)**: Doubt about the effectiveness of customization features, feeling they may not yield expected results.
- **Preference for Simplicity and Efficiency (3 mentions)**: Value placed on simplicity, speed, and efficiency in the user interface, similar to the TurboTax approach.
- **Interest in AI Assistance (3 mentions)**: Openness to AI-generated summaries and assistance, especially as an optional feature for mobile.
- **Specificity in Search Results (3 mentions)**: Appreciation for the specificity of search results, especially when looking for specialists like dermatologists.
- **Concerns About Data Collection (2 mentions)**: Preference for current interfaces over guided conversations due to concerns about data collection.
- **Preference for Direct Access to Providers (2 mentions)**: Desire for direct access to all providers for their insurance without unnecessary steps.

Overall Impressions of ZocDoc

Participants appreciate the modern design and profile access but are frustrated with search accuracy and provider availability:

- **Frustration with Search Results (3 mentions)**: Frustration with search results showing providers outside the specified area and not meeting their needs.
- **Appreciation for Modern Design (2 mentions)**: Positive feedback on the website's modern, well-designed, and easy-to-navigate interface, with features like insurance filters and automatic refresh.
- **Preference for Profile Information (2 mentions)**: Value placed on the ability to view detailed profiles, including education and training, which is lacking in some provider apps.
- **Navigation and Interface Issues (2 mentions)**: Frustration with tedious dropdown menus and the opening of multiple windows, despite the simple interface.

Use of AI and Voice Input for Searching

Participants are open to AI and voice features but have concerns about control, privacy, and efficiency:

- **Concerns About Control and Privacy (4 mentions)**: Concerns about control, permissions, and privacy when using voice

input features.

- **Preference for Typing Over Voice (4 mentions)**: Preference for typing over voice input for control and familiarity, especially on desktops.
- **Voice Input as a Modern Feature (3 mentions)**: Belief that voice input and AI features make the platform feel modern and innovative.
- **Voice Input on Mobile (2 mentions)**: Finding voice input easier on mobile apps compared to typing in smaller dialog boxes.
- **AI-Generated Summaries (2 mentions)**: Openness to AI-generated summaries but preference for reading full reviews for comprehensive understanding.
- **Preference for Convenience (2 mentions)**: Value placed on convenience features like auto-populating information over lengthy question processes.
- **Preference for Typing on Desktops (3 mentions)**: Preference for typing on desktops due to familiarity and simplicity, despite the availability of voice input options.
- **Voice Input on Mobile Apps (2 mentions)**: Finding voice input easier on mobile apps compared to typing, especially in smaller dialog boxes.
- **Flexibility in Interaction Methods (3 mentions)**: Emphasis on the need for flexibility in how they interact with sites, preferring both typing and voice options.
- **Voice Input Not Always Preferred (2 mentions)**: Feeling that voice input does not add value and may lead to biased recommendations, describing it as 'gimmicky'.

Cross-selling

Participants are open to alternative options and non-specialists but prefer consent for changes and specialists for specific conditions:

- **Openness to Alternative Options (2 mentions)**: Acceptance of being offered alternative options if initial preferences are unavailable.
- **Preference for Specialist Care (2 mentions)**: Preference for specialists for specific conditions like hair loss, but comfort with non-specialists for general issues.

Looking for Other Services While Searching for a Provider

Participants prioritize finding a PCP and scheduling appointments based on specific needs and recommendations:

- **Participants prioritize finding a PCP (2 mentions)**: Focus on finding a primary care provider (PCP) for annual physicals and consideration of additional services like pediatric care.
- **Appointments based on specific needs (2 mentions)**: Preference for setting up appointments based on specific needs, such as annual checkups, and following additional suggestions from healthcare providers.

Feature Suggestions

Participants suggest enhancing search with filters, voice commands, and visual aids, and improving user experience with insurance and health record integration:

- **Enhance Search with Filters and Visuals (3 mentions)**: Suggestion for immediate filtering based on known info, visual representation of ratings, and prioritizing insurance and top-rated doctors.
- **Integrate Insurance and Health Records (3 mentions)**: Recommendation for features like taking a picture of insurance cards, syncing health records, and a guide for identifying insurance plans.

- **Voice Commands and Gender Preference (2 mentions)**: Suggestion for adding voice commands for searching and a gender preference option for selecting doctors.

Conclusion

The findings from this Discovery study provide valuable insights into the user experience with ZocDoc. Participants appreciate features like ensuring the system knows about their insurance information upfront and before shopping, the variety of doctor options, and modern design but have concerns about search accuracy, sorting functionality, and the guided search process.

Suggestions include integrating insurance and health records before the patient begins their search, and exploring voice commands. Addressing these concerns and implementing the suggested features can help improve the user experience and increase the adoption of our online scheduling platform.

Other Observations: "Guided Scheduling" Tasks and Interactions

	Participant	Task	Observations	Pains / Friction	Quotes	Insights / Opportunities
1	Briana	PCP / Other	• Was asked to enter "Dermatology" instead of PCP • 👍 Liked the options presented • Selected "Skin problem", then "Dry/itchy skin"	• Believes UI is a list of conditions • Wishes she could choose multiple conditions at a time instead of selecting just one	"I really like this screen. If I didn't know how to describe my condition, I like that they're giving me options to work with."	Consider a version of this design that is multi-select and condition-focused

2	Briana	Ortho	• Did not have a chance to comment on the specific options presented • Selected "Spine & Back"	• Concerned that the options are too general • Worried that there may be too many types of doctors to choose from in the results	"Depending on what kind of pain I have, they may be able to recommend a lot of different doctors, which I'm kind of worried about. I just want one that specializes in the pain areas I have."	Consider additional visual cues to ensure the user knows they are still searching by a specific specialty
3	Briana	OBGYN	• Did not have a chance to comment on the specific options presented • Selected "Annual Exam"	---	---	---
4	Edgar	PCP / Other	• Enters "Dermatology" instead of PCP • 👍 Liked the options presented • Selected "Skin problem", then "Rash" • Also notices the applied filters at the top of the search results screen.	---	"Let's suppose that there are different types of dermatologists. I can make my search more specific, more accurate, more right to the point. You know?" "I think it's great. I'm really doing a very specific search. From there, I can see specialists that can take care of me based on my needs."	---
5	Edgar	Ortho	• Did not have a chance to comment on the specific options presented • Selected "Foot & Ankle"	---	---	---

6	Gayle	PCP / Other	• Selected "Annual Exam" • Wishes there were pre-set preferences or connected health records to help personalize results	---	---	---
7	Ken	PCP / Other	• Did not have a chance to comment on the specific options presented • Selected "Annual Exam" • Believes the options shown will narrow down specific doctors • Expects this to save him time from needing to filter results on his own	---	"Additional questions here are gonna save me time in filtering results." "I would say the more preliminary questions, the easier this would be."	---
8	Louis	Ortho	• Initially, this participant included the practice area in his keyword search (e.g. Orthopedic Leg and Knee) • Later, when asked to enter "Orthopedics" by itself, he was surprised by the list of options shown. • Was asked to select "Leg and Knee"	• Did not feel that the options were helpful in his case • Expected this information earlier in the flow	"It makes sense for an orthopedic because they all have different specialties. It's just not where I expected it" "I feel like it's something you need to do if you just don't know what type of doctor you need."	Only show this design when specificity or guidance is needed. Consider displaying these options in the keyword search recommendations (or "search view")

9	Meagan	Ortho	• 👍 Liked the options presented • Selected "Hand & Wrist"	• Believes the UI is multi-select • Wishes she could choose all options relevant to her conditions	"I like it. It's more specific. I'm wondering, can I pick more than one?" "I want to make sure that I'm with someone who can handle all of that. I think in general, an orthopedic surgeon can. But it's just I don't know."	Consider a version of this design that is multi-select
10	Meagan	OBGYN	• Did not have a chance to comment on the specific options presented • Was asked to select "Annual Exam"	• Frustrated by so many different (and unexpected) types of providers in the search results	"I'm hoping this gets me more customized results, but after my last experience, I don't really know."	Test to ensure the results populated are relevant to the keywords and filters selected
11	Robert	PCP / Other	• 👍 Liked the options presented • Mentions that these options are good for his scenario, because he's not searching for a specific condition at this time. • Selected "Annual Exam"	---	"It's very minimal here, it almost looks like I'm on a completely different website from where I was before." "I think it makes sense to have this this step for 'here's what I'm looking for'. You know? Is it urgent or not? That sort of thing." "I've just moved here, looking for a PCP. I don't have a condition right now that I'm really super concerned about that needs immediate now for this thing.	---